RAG Learning

OCR GCSE Geography B (J384) — Paper 2: People and Society · Topic 5: Urban Futures

2.1 Urban Futures

1. Global Urbanisation Trends

Urbanisation: The process by which an **increasing proportion** of a country's population comes to live in urban areas (towns and cities). It is measured as the percentage of total population living in urban areas — NOT the total number of people in cities.

Key Global Statistics

Year	% Urban Population (global)	Urban Population (approx.)
1950	30%	750 million
2007	50%	3.3 billion (first time majority urban)
2018	55%	4.2 billion
2050 (projected)	68%	~6.7 billion

Urbanisation rates vary dramatically by development level:

Region	% Urban (2020)	Trend
North America	82%	Slow growth; some counter-urbanisation
Europe	75%	Slow growth; some re-urbanisation (gentrification)

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Latin America & Caribbean	81%	Largely already urbanised; growth slowing
Asia	51%	Rapid urbanisation ongoing — China, India, SE Asia
Africa	43%	Fastest urbanisation globally — doubling expected by 2050

Megacities

> **Megacity:** A city with a population exceeding **10 million people**. In 1990 there were 10 megacities; by the mid-2020s there were over 30 (the UN counted 33 in 2025). Most growth in megacities now occurs in LIDCs and EDCs.

City	Country	Population (urban agglomeration)	Classification
Tokyo	Japan	~37.4 million	AC — long ranked the world's largest city (a 2025 UN report using a new city definition ranked Jakarta and Dhaka larger)
Delhi	India	~32.9 million	EDC — one of the fastest growing megacities
Shanghai	China	~29 million	EDC
São Paulo	Brazil	~22.4 million	EDC
Mumbai	India	~21 million	EDC
Lagos	Nigeria	~15 million	EDC (lower-middle income) — one of Africa's largest cities
London	UK	~9.5 million	AC

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Exam Tip: The distinction between urbanisation and urban growth is a classic exam trap. Urbanisation = increasing *proportion* living in cities. Urban growth = increasing *number*. A city can grow in absolute population without urbanisation occurring if the rural population grows at the same rate. State both clearly in high-mark answers.

2. Megacities and World Cities

Megacity — a city with a population of over 10 million. **World city** — a city with global influence in finance, trade, culture and politics (e.g. London, New York, Tokyo, Paris), which may or may not be a megacity.

- In 1950 there were just two megacities (New York and Tokyo); by the mid-2020s there were over 30, most in Asia, Africa and Latin America.
- World cities are linked by flows of money, people, goods and information — they are hubs in the global economy.

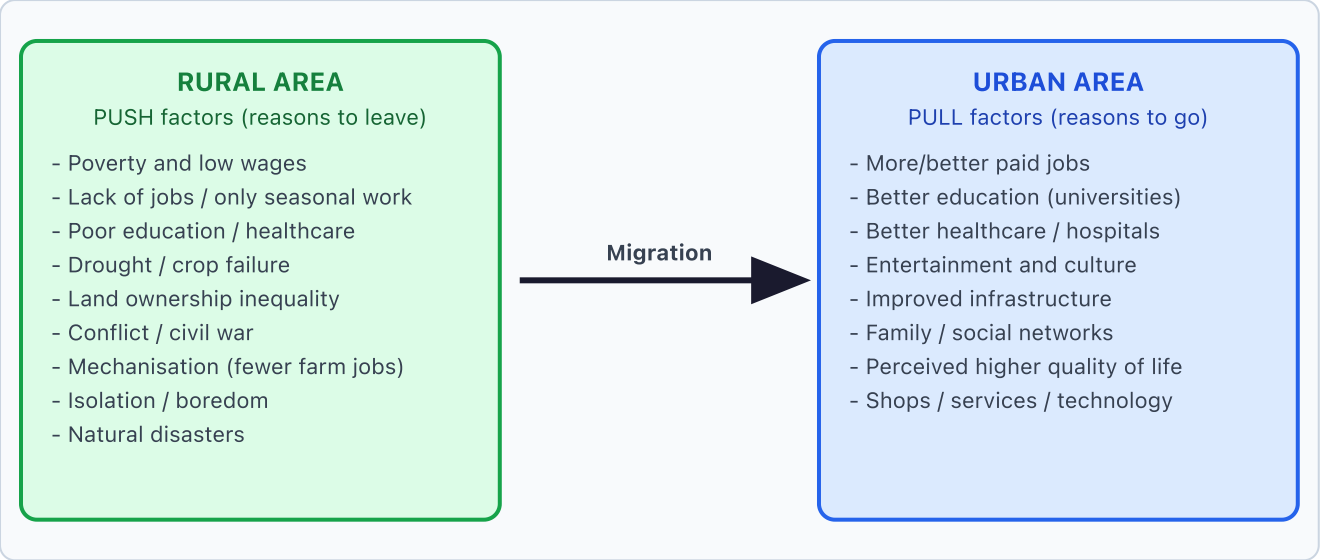
Urbanisation in advanced, emerging and low-income developing countries

Type of country	Urbanisation pattern
Developed (e.g. UK)	Already about 80–85% urban; slow growth; some counter-urbanisation and re-urbanisation (people returning to regenerated city centres)
Emerging (e.g. India, Brazil)	Rapid urbanisation driven by industrialisation and rural–urban migration; growth of megacities
Developing (e.g. Niger)	Lower proportion urban but some of the fastest growth rates; high natural increase in cities

3. Causes of Urbanisation

Urbanisation results from two processes: **rural-urban migration** (people moving from countryside to city) and **natural increase** (birth rate exceeding death rate within cities).

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Push-Pull Factors in Depth — With Statistics

Push-pull theory (Ravenstein, 1885) explains migration as driven by negative conditions at origin and positive conditions at destination. In reality, migration decisions are complex and shaped by personal networks, distance, cost, and government policies.

Push Factor	Supporting Evidence
Agricultural mechanisation reducing farm jobs	In India, agricultural employment fell from 60% of the workforce in 2000 to ~42% by 2020 (World Bank), as millions left farming for urban jobs.
Land inequality / landlessness	In Brazil in the 1970s–1990s, the top 1% of landowners held over 44% of agricultural land, pushing landless rural workers towards cities like São Paulo.
Climate shocks and drought	The 2009–2011 drought in the Sahel affected 10 million people; climate change could create 216 million internal climate migrants globally by 2050, 86 million of them in sub-Saharan Africa (World Bank, 2021).
Low rural wages	In Nigeria, rural farm incomes are typically far below urban earnings; the national minimum wage (₦30,000/month from 2019, raised to ₦70,000 in 2024) mainly applies to formal urban jobs, and even informal urban work often pays more than rural agriculture.

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Conflict and instability	Syria's civil war (from 2011) displaced 6 million internally; many fled to Damascus, Aleppo, and eventually abroad. Northeast Nigeria's Boko Haram insurgency has displaced over 2 million people, mostly to towns and cities within the north-east such as Maiduguri.

Pull Factor	Supporting Evidence
Higher urban wages	The urban wage premium in developing countries is typically 15–30% above rural wages for equivalent work, and up to 200% for skilled urban jobs (ILO data).
Better education access	In Nigeria, urban areas have ~3x more secondary schools per capita than rural areas; university access is almost exclusively urban.
Healthcare	Under-5 mortality in rural Nigeria is much higher than in urban areas (NDHS, 2018) — a powerful pull for young families.
Social networks / family chain migration	Migrants follow established networks — a family member or friend who has already migrated reduces the cost, risk, and uncertainty of moving. This explains why migration streams often link specific rural regions to specific cities.
Perceived opportunity	Even the informal economy in Lagos or Mumbai offers more diverse income opportunities than subsistence farming — hawking, domestic work, construction, and petty trade all provide income that is irregular but potentially higher than rural work.

Exam Tip: When asked about push-pull factors, avoid listing them without context. Examiners at higher grades reward analysis: explain *why* a factor is significant (e.g. "Mechanisation is particularly powerful because it permanently removes jobs, leaving no reason to stay — unlike drought, which is temporary"). Use the word "because" repeatedly to force explanation rather than description.

Natural Increase in Cities

In LIDCs and EDCs, cities also grow through **natural increase** — a higher birth rate than death rate within the urban population. Migrants are often young adults (reproductive age), which raises the urban birth rate. Improved healthcare in cities reduces child mortality compared to rural areas. In Lagos, for

example, the natural increase rate is approximately 3% per year — meaning even without migration, the city would double in population within 23 years.

AC vs LIDC/EDC Urbanisation

Feature	ACs (e.g. UK, USA)	LIDCs and EDCs (e.g. India, Nigeria)
Stage of urbanisation	Already highly urbanised (75–85%); growth slowing or reversing	Rapidly urbanising; some cities growing at 3–5% per year
Main driver	Economic restructuring; suburbanisation/counter-urbanisation now prevalent	Rural-urban migration + high natural increase
Key challenge	Urban decay, deprivation, housing affordability, congestion	Insufficient housing, services, infrastructure for rapid population growth
Squatter settlements?	Rare / managed	Very common — ~1 billion people globally live in informal settlements
Historical timing	Urbanisation occurred gradually over 150+ years (Industrial Revolution from 1760s) allowing infrastructure to develop in parallel	Rapid urbanisation compressed into decades — infrastructure cannot keep up
Government capacity	Strong planning systems, building regulations, welfare provision	Often insufficient revenue, corruption, weak enforcement of planning law

4. Case Study: London — A Major UK City

London: location and importance

- Located in south-east England on the **River Thames**, close to mainland Europe. Greater London has about **9 million people**.

- **Within the UK:** the capital and seat of government; generates around a **quarter of UK GDP**; the hub of the national road, rail and air networks.
- **In the wider world:** a **world city** and one of the two leading global financial centres (with New York); Heathrow is one of the world's busiest international airports; home to many company headquarters, universities and cultural institutions.

Impacts of national and international migration

Type	Pattern	Impact on London
International migration	Over a third of Londoners were born outside the UK. Waves of migration from the Caribbean (Windrush generation, from 1948), South Asia, Africa, EU countries (especially after 2004) and more recently Hong Kong and Ukraine.	A young, diverse workforce; over 300 languages spoken; vibrant cultural districts (e.g. Brick Lane, Southall, Brixton); pressure on housing and school places in some boroughs; enriches food, music and festivals (Notting Hill Carnival).
National migration	Young adults (20s) move to London from the rest of the UK for university and jobs; many older people and families move out to the South East and beyond.	London has a younger average age than the UK; a "brain drain" from other regions to London; outward movement of families fuels commuter settlements around the city.

Opportunities

Type	Examples
Social and economic — cultural mix	Cultural diversity gives a wide range of food, festivals, music, theatre and faith communities.
Recreation and entertainment	West End theatres, museums (most of the national ones are free), the Olympic Park at Stratford, the Royal Parks.

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Employment	Finance (the City and Canary Wharf), creative and tech industries (Shoreditch "Tech City"), tourism, government, health and education.
Integrated transport	The Underground, Overground, buses, DLR, trams and the **Elizabeth line** (opened 2022) link together with one ticketing system (Oyster/contactless), reducing car use. Over 70% of journeys into central London are by public transport.
Environmental — urban greening	About half of London's area is green or blue space. In 2019 it became the world's first **National Park City**. Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park turned contaminated industrial land into parkland and wetlands.

Challenges

Type	Examples
Urban deprivation and inequality	Some of the richest and poorest areas in the UK sit close together. Life expectancy can differ by around 15–20 years between wealthy areas (e.g. Kensington) and deprived areas (e.g. parts of Tower Hamlets and Newham).
Housing	Average house prices are over £500,000 — around 12 times average earnings. Overcrowding, long social housing waiting lists and high rents push key workers out.
Education and health	Wide gaps in exam results and health outcomes between boroughs, although London's state schools have improved significantly since the 2000s.
Employment	Despite high average incomes, some inner boroughs have higher unemployment, and many people work in low-paid, insecure jobs.
Environmental — dereliction and brownfield sites	Former docks and industrial areas in East London were left derelict after deindustrialisation. Brownfield sites are being redeveloped (Docklands, Stratford, King's Cross).
Greenfield sites and urban sprawl	The **green belt** limits outward growth, but there is pressure to build on it. Sprawl affects the **rural–urban fringe** — loss of farmland, more traffic and

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	the growth of **commuter settlements** such as Sevenoaks, Reading and Chelmsford, where house prices rise and village services may decline.
Waste and pollution	London produces millions of tonnes of household waste a year. Air pollution from traffic contributes to thousands of early deaths each year — the **Ultra Low Emission Zone (ULEZ)**, expanded to all of Greater London in 2023, charges the most polluting vehicles.

Exam Tip: Exam questions on your UK city often ask you to "evaluate" the opportunities or challenges. Use the categories in the specification — social, economic and environmental — and make sure each point has a specific London fact (a place, a number or a scheme).

5. Case Study: Urban Regeneration — London Docklands (LDDC)

Case Study: London Docklands Development Corporation (LDDC)

Background — why the docks declined: London's docklands (Wapping, Poplar, Isle of Dogs, Bermondsey, Surrey Quays) were once the world's busiest port. From the 1960s, **containerisation** revolutionised global shipping — standard shipping containers required deeper water, larger ships, and far fewer dock workers. The old docks were too small and shallow. By the 1970s the docks were almost entirely closed. The area was a wasteland of derelict warehouses, closed factories, and high unemployment. The resident population (mainly white working-class Cockneys) fell by around a fifth in the 1970s, and unemployment was more than double the London average.

LDDC established 1981 under Margaret Thatcher as an Urban Development Corporation (UDC) — a government body with powers to buy land, grant planning permission, attract private investment, and build infrastructure, bypassing normal local democratic controls (the local councils — Tower Hamlets and Southwark — were largely sidelined).

What was built:

- **Canary Wharf** — transformed the Isle of Dogs into one of Europe's largest financial centres; One Canada Square (1991) was the UK's tallest building for about 20 years; now home to HSBC, Barclays, Citibank, Reuters, the Daily Mirror, and 120,000 workers
- **22,000 new homes** built (though mainly luxury apartments and market-rate; very limited affordable housing)

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- **Docklands Light Railway (DLR)** opened 1987 — connecting the Docklands to the City and carrying around 100–120 million passengers/year
- **London City Airport** opened 1987 — handling about 5 million passengers/year before the pandemic
- **ExCeL London** conference and exhibition centre
- Surrey Quays shopping centre; Tobacco Dock retail conversion

Economic achievements: The Docklands GDP grew enormously; 100,000+ jobs created; land values increased 20× between 1981 and 1998; major tax revenues generated. Canary Wharf now generates billions of pounds a year in tax revenue. The financial district has become a genuine rival to the City of London.

Criticisms and limitations:

- Primarily benefited incoming wealthy workers and businesses, not the existing local community
- Original Docklanders (working-class community) were displaced by rising rents and house prices — unable to afford new housing in their own area
- Affordable housing was a very small fraction (target 20%, actual <10%) of new homes built; much housing priced at £300,000–£1m+ by the 1990s
- Community infrastructure (schools, health centres, community halls) lagged far behind housing and commercial development — a House of Commons Committee report (1988) criticised this explicitly
- Local councils and communities had no meaningful input into plans — top-down, profit-driven model imposed by central government
- LDDC wound up in 1998; some argue the approach favoured developers over residents
- Tower Hamlets, the host borough, remained in the top 5% most deprived areas of England throughout the LDDC period and beyond — indicating regeneration did not "trickle down" effectively

Overall evaluation: The Docklands regeneration was economically transformative — creating a major world financial district where derelict docks stood. However, it is frequently cited as an example of **regeneration that prioritised economic growth over social equity**. The benefits were not equally distributed — the original community saw relatively few gains while property investors and global corporations profited enormously. The key lesson: flagship economic regeneration can succeed without achieving social regeneration. This gap between economic and

social outcomes has shaped subsequent UK regeneration policy, though affordable housing delivery remains contested in 2024. A comparison table is given below.

Criterion	Evidence of Success	Evidence of Failure / Criticism
Economic	100,000+ jobs; Canary Wharf as global financial hub; billions of pounds a year in tax revenue	Jobs required high skill levels not available to original community; benefits accrued mainly to corporations and developers
Social	22,000 new homes built; DLR improved connectivity for all residents; arts and cultural venues	<10% affordable housing; Tower Hamlets stayed in top 5% most deprived; original community displaced
Environmental	Derelict wasteland transformed; dock water cleaned; new parks and public spaces on waterfront	Large-scale brownfield contamination cleared, but original industrial character and community lost
Process	UDC model enabled fast decision-making without bureaucratic delays	Democratic deficit — local councils and residents excluded from decision-making

6. Sustainable Urban Living

Sustainable City: An urban area designed and managed to meet the needs of its current population **without compromising the ability of future generations** to meet their needs. Sustainability in cities involves environmental, economic, AND social dimensions.

Features of a Sustainable City

Feature	Detail	Example
Renewable energy	Solar panels on buildings, wind turbines, district heating from	Freiburg (Germany): 'plus-energy' solar houses in its Solarsiedlung produce more

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	renewables; zero-carbon energy supply	energy than they use; Masdar City (UAE): solar-powered
Public transport	Efficient, affordable public transport reduces car dependency; integrated bus/tram/metro systems	Freiburg's tram network; Copenhagen, where around 60% of commutes to work and study are by bike; London's Oyster card integrated ticketing
Pedestrianisation	Car-free zones in city centres; walking encouraged; reduces pollution and accidents	Norwich, Exeter, York city centres; Copenhagen's Strøget — one of Europe's longest pedestrian shopping streets
Recycling and waste	High recycling rates; composting; waste-to-energy; producer responsibility	Freiburg: 70%+ recycling rate; Sweden: <1% of waste goes to landfill
Green spaces	Parks, allotments, tree planting; urban parks maintain biodiversity and mental health	London: 47% green space; Sheffield: 61 parks; Singapore: "City in a Garden" approach
Mixed-use development	Combining residential, commercial, and leisure uses in same area reduces travel distances	BedZED (London); most traditional European city districts
Energy-efficient buildings	High insulation standards; passive solar design; Passivhaus standard	BedZED: uses 88% less heating energy than standard UK homes

Case Study: BedZED, London (Sustainable Development)

Beddington Zero Energy Development in Sutton, South London — completed 2002, designed by architect Bill Dunster for the Peabody Trust. A mixed-use development of 82 homes plus work spaces. Features include: super-insulation eliminating need for central heating; on-site combined heat and power (CHP) plant using wood chip waste; rooftop wind cowls for ventilation; solar panels; rainwater harvesting; green roofs; car club and electric vehicle charging. Monitoring found residents used ~88% less space-heating energy and about a quarter less electricity than average UK homes. Carbon-neutral design. Limitations: expensive to build; some systems (CHP plant)

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broke down and are now switched off; showed that high sustainability standards are technically achievable but may need more robust maintenance planning.

Case Study: Freiburg, Germany (Sustainable City)

Often cited as Europe's "green capital." Key features: 30% of journeys by bicycle (400 km of cycle lanes); an excellent tram system; a strong solar industry and 'plus-energy' solar housing; Vauban district (population 5,500) is almost entirely car-free with high-quality public transport; 42% of city is forest (owned by the city). Key lesson: sustainable transport, renewable energy, and green spaces can coexist with a thriving urban economy.

7. Transport Solutions

Solution	Detail	Effectiveness / Evidence
Congestion charging	Drivers pay to enter a designated zone at peak times. Reduces traffic, raises revenue for public transport investment.	London (introduced 2003): reduced traffic within the zone by ~15–30%; raised £160m+/year for TfL (reinvested in buses). Extended as ULEZ (Ultra Low Emission Zone) 2019, expanded 2021 and 2023 to all London boroughs.
Park and Ride	Large car parks on city fringe with frequent bus/tram service into centre. Reduces inner-city traffic and car park demand.	Oxford, Cambridge, York, Edinburgh — all have extensive P&R systems. Reduces city centre traffic by 3–8% in most studies. Limitations: adds journey time; attracts car journeys that would otherwise not happen.
Tram / light rail systems	High-capacity public transport on dedicated tracks; reduces need for cars; links suburbs to city centre efficiently.	Manchester Metrolink: 100 tram stops, 100km of track, 44 million journeys/year (2019). Sheffield Supertram, Edinburgh Trams. Evidence of significant modal shift from car where trams have good coverage.

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Cycle infrastructure	Dedicated cycle lanes (separated from traffic); secure parking; bike hire schemes; reduced risk increases cycling uptake.	London's segregated Cycle Superhighways greatly increased cycling on their routes; TfL Santander Cycles (Boris Bikes): 10+ million hires/year. Still far behind Amsterdam/Copenhagen model. UK average: 3% cycle mode share vs Netherlands 27%.
ULEZ (Ultra Low Emission Zone)	Older, high-polluting vehicles charged to enter the zone; aims to improve air quality. Works alongside congestion charging.	London ULEZ (expanded to all boroughs August 2023): reduced NO_2 by 44% in the original zone; reduced toxic air pollution hospital admissions. Politically controversial — many drivers unable to afford newer compliant vehicles.
Pedestrianisation	Excluding vehicles from city centre streets; creates pleasant, safer urban space; increases retail footfall.	UK city centres (Exeter, Norwich, York, Oxford High Street): evidence of increased retail spending, reduced accidents, improved air quality. Some resistance from disabled and elderly residents who depended on vehicles.

8. Urbanisation in LIDCs and EDCs — Squatter Settlements

Squatter settlement / Informal settlement / Slum: A densely populated area of a city where housing has been **illegally built** on land not owned by the residents, using temporary materials, without official permission. Known by various local names: *favela* (Brazil), *barrio* (Latin America), *shanty town* (general), *bidonville* (French Africa), *bustee* (India).

Why Do Squatter Settlements Develop?

- Rural-urban migrants arrive in cities faster than formal housing can be built
- Migrants cannot afford formal sector rents or house prices
- Land on the city periphery, flood plains, steep hillsides, or near railways/factories is undesirable — squatters occupy it with less risk of eviction
- Governments in LIDCs lack resources to provide social housing at scale

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- Informal settlements develop incrementally — start with temporary shelters, gradually improve over years

Characteristics of Squatter Settlements

Feature	Detail
Housing	Built from salvaged materials — corrugated iron, plastic sheets, cardboard, breeze blocks. Often 1–2 rooms for extended families.
Water supply	Often no piped water; residents buy from water vendors at 10× the price paid by formal city residents, or use shared/contaminated sources
Sanitation	Few or no toilets/sewers; open sewers or defecation in the open; very high disease risk (cholera, typhoid, diarrhoea)
Electricity	Often illegally tapped from nearby power lines; fire risk; unreliable
Employment	Mostly informal economy — street vending, waste picking, domestic work, small manufacturing
Security	No legal title to land; constant threat of eviction; high crime rates in some areas
Health	High rates of respiratory disease (overcrowding, cooking fires); waterborne diseases; malnutrition; high infant mortality
Global scale	Approximately 1 billion people (1 in 7 globally) live in informal settlements (UN Habitat)

9. Case Study: Lagos, Nigeria (EDC) — Urbanisation in Africa

Case Study: Lagos, Nigeria — Africa's Megacity

Background and Location: Lagos is Nigeria's largest city, located on the Bight of Benin (Atlantic coast) in southwest Nigeria. It is the economic capital of Nigeria (though Abuja is the political capital) and the largest city in sub-Saharan Africa, with a metropolitan population of approximately 14–15 million (2023), growing at around 3% per year. By 2050, the UN projects Lagos will have over 30 million people.

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Population Growth Timeline:

- 1950: ~290,000 people
- 1970: ~1.4 million (Lagos was Nigeria's capital until 1991 and its main port)
- 1990: ~5 million (rapid industrialisation; oil economy attracting workers)
- 2000: ~7.5 million
- 2015: ~12 million
- 2023: ~15 million (metropolitan area); ~24 million (urban agglomeration including surrounding areas)

Why Lagos grew so fast:

- Nigeria's oil boom from the 1970s concentrated wealth and government spending in Lagos
- Colonial legacy: Lagos was Nigeria's administrative and commercial centre under British rule
- Rural push from agricultural collapse: Nigeria went from a food exporter in 1960 to an importer by the 1980s; the oil boom destroyed agricultural competitiveness, pushing rural workers to cities
- Civil war (Biafra, 1967–1970) displaced millions; many eventually settled in Lagos
- High natural increase: Nigeria has a total fertility rate of ~5.3 children per woman (2020); urban birth rates remain high
- Informal economy opportunities: Lagos generates approximately 25–30% of Nigeria's total GDP despite having only ~8% of the population

Infrastructure Challenges:

- **Traffic:** Lagos is consistently ranked among the world's worst cities for traffic congestion (TomTom Traffic Index). Average commute times exceed 2 hours each way. The city's road network was designed for ~1 million people. The Lagos BRT (Bus Rapid Transit), opened 2008, carries 200,000+ passengers/day — Africa's largest BRT — but is overwhelmed.
- **Water:** Lagos Water Corporation officially supplies 210 million litres/day — but the city needs 700+ million litres/day. Most residents rely on private boreholes (often contaminated) or buy from water vendors at up to 10× the piped water price.
- **Electricity:** EKEDC (Lagos electricity distributor) provides power for an average of 8–12 hours/day in better-served areas, often far less. Most businesses run on diesel generators, adding to air pollution and costs.

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- **Waste:** Lagos produces approximately 10,000 tonnes of solid waste per day; formal collection capacity is ~40% of this. The Olusosun landfill (one of the world's largest) has received waste for 30+ years and is now critically over capacity.
- **Flooding:** Much of Lagos is built on low-lying islands and coastal land. Annual flooding affects millions of residents; climate change is increasing flood frequency and severity.

Makoko — The Floating Slum: Makoko is one of Lagos's most well-known informal settlements, built on stilts over Lagos Lagoon. Key facts:

- Population estimated at 100,000–300,000 people (difficult to census accurately)
- Buildings are constructed on wooden stilts above the water; residents travel by canoe
- No formal sanitation — sewage goes directly into the lagoon; the water is heavily polluted
- No piped water; residents use lagoon water (contaminated) or buy bottled/tanker water
- Children are rowed to school in canoes; there is a floating school (though the original structure collapsed in 2016 and a new one was rebuilt)
- Community is mostly from the Egun fishing community who have lived on the lagoon for generations — it is both an economic necessity and a cultural community
- In 2012, Lagos state government partially demolished Makoko with minimal notice, triggering international protests from human rights organisations. Many residents rebuilt.
- **Why it exists:** Land on Lagos Island is among the most expensive in Africa; waterfront land is formally controlled. The lagoon is unregulated space where poor migrants can build without land costs.

The Informal Economy in Lagos:

- An estimated 65–70% of Lagos workers are in the informal economy — street hawking, small trade, motorcycle taxis ("okadas"), domestic work, building and repair
- "Alaba International Market" — one of Africa's largest electronics markets — is largely informal
- The Lagos informal economy is estimated to be worth tens of billions of US dollars per year
- Okada (motorcycle taxis) provided critical transport for millions of poorer residents — the Lagos state government banned them from major roads in 2022, displacing hundreds of thousands of workers overnight, illustrating the fragility of informal livelihoods

Improvements and Government Response:

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- Lagos BRT (2008) — Africa's largest Bus Rapid Transit system, 22 km route, 200,000+ passengers/day
- Eko Atlantic — a new city being built on reclaimed land adjacent to Victoria Island, designed for businesses and wealthy residents. Critics call it a "city for the rich" that does nothing for the urban poor.
- Lagos State has invested in CCTV, policing reform, and formal markets to reduce crime
- Drainage improvement projects to reduce flooding — though progress is slow relative to population growth

Exam Tip — Lagos vs Mumbai: Lagos and Mumbai (both in EDCs) are often compared. Key contrasts: Nigeria's GDP per capita (around $1,000 or less in 2024, after the naira's devaluation) is now well below India's (~$2,700), and India's urban middle class is much larger. Lagos has less formal government capacity to fund improvement schemes than Mumbai. Lagos also faces the added challenge that Nigeria's federal government revenues are dominated by oil — which creates boom-bust cycles affecting infrastructure investment. In exam answers, specify whether a problem is LIDC/EDC-specific or universal.

Lagos — Location, Importance and Opportunities

Importance: Lagos is Nigeria's main port (Apapa and Tin Can Island handle most of the country's imports), its commercial and financial centre, and home to the Nigerian Stock Exchange. Nollywood, Nigeria's film industry — one of the largest in the world by number of films — is based in and around Lagos. Murtala Muhammed Airport makes it a hub for West Africa.

Social opportunities:

- Better access to **services** than rural areas — more schools, universities (University of Lagos) and hospitals.
- Access to **resources** such as piped water and electricity, even if supply is unreliable, compared with rural areas that may have none.
- A diverse cultural and entertainment scene — music (Afrobeats), film and fashion industries.

Economic opportunities:

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- **Jobs** in manufacturing, services, finance, oil-related industries and the port — far more varied than in rural areas.
- A booming **tech sector** — "Yabacon Valley" in Yaba hosts many start-ups and hubs.
- The informal economy provides work for millions who cannot find formal jobs, and gives a first foothold for new migrants.

Urban Planning Scheme for the Urban Poor — Makoko Floating School and Lagos slum upgrading

- The **Makoko Floating School** (2013) was a prototype triangular building on floating plastic barrels, designed by architect Kunlé Adeyemi. It could rise and fall with the water and gave the community a school and meeting space that would not flood.
- It collapsed in a storm in 2016, but the design was refined into the MFS II and MFS III prototypes, and the idea of floating buildings has been promoted as a low-cost, flood-proof housing model.
- The **Lagos Metropolitan Development and Governance Project** (World Bank funded, 2006–2013) upgraded nine slum areas: drains were cleared to reduce flooding, roads paved, street lights installed and solid-waste collection improved for over a million people.
- **Evaluation:** such schemes improve quality of life cheaply and keep communities together, but they are small compared with the scale of need, and residents fear eviction because they lack legal land titles.

10. Urban Issues in LIDCs and EDCs

Issue	Detail	Example
Traffic congestion	Rapid motorisation as incomes rise; poor road infrastructure; mixed traffic (pedestrians, rickshaws, cars, buses); poor public transport	Mumbai: average commute speed 12 km/h in peak hours; Delhi: among the most congested cities globally (TomTom); Lagos: commuters spend average 4+ hours in traffic daily

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Air pollution	Vehicle exhaust (older, poorly maintained vehicles); industrial emissions; domestic cooking fires; construction dust	Delhi: PM2.5 levels regularly 10–20× WHO safe limit; "AQI hazardous" for weeks in winter; air pollution was linked to about 1.7 million deaths in India in 2019. Lagos: vehicle emissions worsened by fuel quality (high-sulphur diesel)
Inadequate sanitation	Insufficient sewage infrastructure; open sewers; rivers used as open sewers	Dharavi: 1 toilet per 1,440 people; Mithi River in Mumbai severely polluted; Makoko (Lagos): sewage directly into lagoon
Water supply	Pipes inadequate; contamination; inequitable supply (rich areas get piped water, poor pay vendors); groundwater over-extraction	Lagos: formal supply only 30% of need; Mumbai gets water for only 2–4 hours/day in many areas; Jakarta sinking due to groundwater extraction
Waste management	Insufficient formal collection; illegal dumping; open landfills; burning of waste	Lagos: Olusosun landfill critically overcapacity; waste pickers (informal recyclers) handle much of the city's waste; Dharavi processes 80% of Mumbai's plastic waste informally
Crime and insecurity	Poverty, inequality, unemployment — especially youth unemployment — drives property crime and gang activity	São Paulo: gang-related violence; Lagos: "area boys" gangs controlling markets; rapid decline in murder rate in some favelas following targeted social programmes

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